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■ People arrive with their luggage before the departure of a bus slated to evacuate foreign passport holders, mainly Austrian and Polish, out of Israel, at a bus stop in Tel Aviv yesterday.
AFP

Trump wants ‘real end’ to Israel-Iran conflict, not truce

China accuses US President of ‘pouring oil’ on the mounting conflict

WASHINGTON

US President Donald Trump said he wants a “real end” to the conflict between Israel and Iran, not just a ceasefire, as the two countries traded fire for a fifth day yesterday.

Trump said that he wanted a “complete give-up” by Iran in return for peace. “I’m not looking for a ceasefire, we’re looking at better than a ceasefire,” he told reporters on the plane home after cutting short his attendance at the G7 summit in Canada.

Trump again warned Iran against targeting US troops and assets in the Middle East, saying “we’ll come down so hard, it’d be gloves off”.

Trump had earlier issued an extraordinary warning on his Truth Social platform, saying: “Everyone should immediately evacuate Tehran!”

Yesterday, Israel’s military lifted air raid warnings for the country’s centre and north, saying it had intercepted “most” of a salvo of fresh missiles fired from Iran.

Explosions were heard over Tel Aviv and Jerusalem shortly after air raid sirens sounded in many parts of Israel following

UAE ACTIVATES AIRPORT EMERGENCY PLAN

The UAE has taken all necessary steps to guarantee continuous airport operations across the UAE, the Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs, and Port Security (ICP) said yesterday. This includes close coordination with all operational entities to address the fallout from recent regional and political developments that led to airspace closures in certain countries. The primary goal is to ensure the safety and smooth movement of passengers without compromising service quality.

The ICP clarified that its approved emergency business continuity plan was immediately activated when these events unfolded.

The Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) also decided to activate the GCC Emergency Management Centre to take all necessary precautionary measures. This includes close monitoring of environmental and radiological indicators and ensuring technical readiness to address any emerging threat. — *Gulf News Report*

missile launches from Iran, the Israeli military said. The military added in a statement that “several missiles” had been launched and “most of them were intercepted”, while residents in the coastal hub of Tel Aviv and the north were told they could leave their shelters.

Direct impacts

Iranian media said several blasts were heard yesterday in the central city of Isfahan, which hosts multiple nuclear facilities. The Israeli military said its forces struck several locations in western Iran, hitting “dozens” of missile launchers.

There appear to have been “direct impacts” on the underground part of Iran’s Natanz nuclear site during Israel’s attacks, the UN’s atomic watchdog said.

Meanwhile, China accused President Donald Trump of “pouring oil” on the mounting conflict. “Fanning the flames, pouring oil, making threats and mounting pressure will not help to promote the de-escalation of the situation, but will only intensify and widen the conflict,” foreign ministry spokesman Guo Jiakun said.

Russia said it was ready to act as a peace broker between Israel and Iran, but that Israel was showing reluctance to accept outside mediation.

More than 600 foreign nationals have crossed from Iran into neighbouring Azerbaijan since Israel began striking the country last Friday, a government official in Baku said.

— *Agencies*
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Poll finds public turning to AI bots for news updates

1 in 5 used AI for queries on current events

PARIS

People are increasingly turning to generative artificial intelligence chatbots like ChatGPT to follow day-to-day news, a respected media report published yesterday found.

The yearly survey from the Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism found “for the first time” that significant numbers of people were using chatbots to get headlines and updates, director Mitali Mukherjee wrote.

Just seven per cent of people report using AI to find news, according to the

poll of 97,000 people in 48 countries, carried out by YouGov. But the proportion is higher among the young, at 12 per cent of under-35s and 15 per cent of under-25s.

Most widely used

The biggest-name chatbot — OpenAI’s ChatGPT — is the most widely used, followed by Google’s Gemini and Meta’s Llama. Many more used AI to summarise (27 per cent), translate (24 per cent) or recommend (21 per cent) articles, while almost one in five asked questions about current events. — *AFP*

UAE among the world’s top 5 in competitiveness

NATION 1ST GLOBALLY FOR ABSENCE OF BUREAUCRACY, 2ND FOR ADAPTABILITY

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

The UAE jumped from 28th place in 2009 to join the world’s top five nations in competitiveness, government efficiency, the strength of its legislation, and the quality of its business environment, according to the 2025 World Competitiveness Ranking released by the International Institute for Management Development (IMD).

The results were announced during a Cabinet meeting held yesterday at Qasr Al Watan in Abu Dhabi, chaired by His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai.

“These achievements are a testament to years of dedicated work and the relentless pursuit of government excellence,” Shaikh Mohammad said in a series of tweets on X following the meeting. “The UAE has risen from 28th place in 2009 to now stand among the top five globally in competitiveness, government efficiency, the strength of legislation, and the quality of its business environment.”

Pursuit of excellence

The UAE also ranked first in the world for the absence of bureaucracy, second for adaptability, and fourth for government efficiency, marking a milestone in the country’s ongoing drive to reshape the nature of public service.

“These achievements are a testament to years of dedicated

work and the relentless pursuit of government excellence,” Shaikh Mohammad added. He credited the nation’s progress to a strategic vision set more than 16 years ago, which saw the establishment of a federal competitiveness centre and the integration of efforts across all key government entities.

According to the report, the UAE’s climb to first place globally for the absence of bureaucracy was made possible thanks to sweeping reforms that have eliminated unnecessary procedures and streamlined public services. The country was also ranked second for adaptability, a measure of how rapidly it can respond to changing global and domestic circumstances.

During the Cabinet meeting, the government approved new housing support for more than 1,838 Emirati citizens in the first half of 2025, amounting to Dh1.2 billion.

Other major decisions included approving the results and ongoing projects of the Emirates Council for Balanced Development. The council has launched initiatives to boost tourism, create job opportunities for youth, and support small businesses across the country.

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